

kehlani.



an essay.

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“hey..if you see these signs [of] i’m not sleeping, i’m not eating, i’m talking really fast...i’m in crisis.”

kehlani on living with a bipolar & bpd diagnosis.

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when creating our central character..

we wanted her name to stand for something deeply intentional. named after r&b star kehlani (and pulitzer prize poet gwendolyn brooks)..



..inspired by the singer's raw honesty in opening up about her clinical diagnosis to spark conversations around black mental health.

our show pulls back the curtain on a reality too often masked by silence. for this demographic, a crisis doesn't always look like falling apart. swipe for a perspective, and the signs you can't ignore.

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the **inspo.** in kehlani's words.

the **reality:** "people think a diagnosis is relief... but sometimes it just makes everything real. it's the beginning of a whole different kind of fight."



the **non-negotiable routine:** "i am clinically bipolar... i take medicine. i have to go to the gym; it's not an option. i have to have a routine supporting my wellness so i can freaking survive."

the **lifeline:** "hey, if you see these signs [of] i'm not sleeping, i'm not eating, i'm talking really fast...call my psychiatrist. i'm in crisis."

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our core intent & mission.

the mission: shifting the narrative away from silent, isolated suffering and toward structural, community-supported healing.



the intent: to bring awareness to the layered nuances of black female mental health.

dismantling the mask: exposing the heavy psychological toll of the "strong black woman" stereotype that forces resilience at the cost of wellness.

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crisis looks different here.

the **traditional view**: society expects a mental health crisis to look like sudden public breakdowns or total exhaustion.



the **high-functioning trap**: for black women, an emotional or manic crisis often presents as extreme over-functioning.

the **mask**: hyper-productivity, saying yes to everything, stepping into every room, and moving way too fast for anyone to notice the pain.

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roadmap. signs to look for.

unusual energy shifts: days without sleep or eating, paired with sudden, uncharacteristic bursts of intense productivity.



pressured patterns: noticeably rapid, urgent, or continuous speech during high-stress periods.

the action step: don't wait for a total collapse. build a crisis roadmap with your circle early, and intentionally check in on your high-functioning friends.

key health metrics.

Overall Prevalence: black adults in the U.S. experience mental health conditions at similar or higher rates than white adults, yet they are significantly less likely to receive treatment.



Treatment Disparities: black adults are 36% less likely than white adults to have received mental health treatment in the past year. only about 4% of psychologists and 2% of psychiatrists in the U.S. are black.

black women report symptoms of anxiety and depression (ie: major depressive episodes) at higher rates than black men (in campus/community studies).

general support & resources 1.

Therapy for Black Girls: An online space and directory dedicated to encouraging the mental wellness of Black women and girls.



The Confess Project: An organization that trains barbers and salon workers to become mental health first-responders for Black men.

Boris Lawrence Henson Foundation: Provides mental health resources, education, and anti-stigma campaigns specifically for the Black community

general support & resources 2.

Melanin and Mental Health: Connects individuals with culturally competent clinicians serving Black and Hispanic/Latinx communities



National Crisis Line: Call or text 988 for the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline (free, confidential, and available 24/7)

text STEVE to 741741 to reach the **Steve Fund Crisis Text Line**, dedicated to the mental health of young people of color.

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